ENCHANTED MEDICAL AESTHETICS



PRE & POST WORKOUT NUTRITION GUIDE

Simple Fuel for Better Workouts

www.enchantedmedicalaesthetics.com

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WELCOME

I'm Dr. Bridget Martin, a Doctor of Nursing Practice and founder of Enchanted Medical Aesthetics. I'm passionate about helping people fuel their bodies in a way that supports movement, recovery, and long-term consistency.

This guide was created to simplify what to eat before and after workouts, using practical, food-first guidance that fits into real life.

You're about to explore a clear, flexible approach to workout nutrition—one that focuses on supporting energy during training and recovery afterward, without rigid rules or complicated strategies.

You don't need to follow every suggestion perfectly. Use this guide as a reference, adapt it to your routine, and build habits that feel sustainable over time.

Let's connect!

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HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is designed to help you fuel your workouts and recovery in a simple, practical way. It focuses on what to eat before and after exercise to support energy, performance, and muscle recovery, without strict rules, calorie counting, or complicated nutrition plans.

Use this guide as a flexible reference to make better food choices around your workouts, based on how you train, how much time you have, and how your body feels.



This guide is ideal for adults who:

- Work out regularly or are just getting started
- Want better energy during workouts
- Want to recover faster and feel less fatigued
- Feel unsure about what or when to eat around exercise
- Prefer simple, balanced nutrition without extremes

There is no one “perfect” pre- or post-workout meal. Consistency, balance, and listening to your body matter more than exact timing or rigid rules.

How to Personalize This Guide

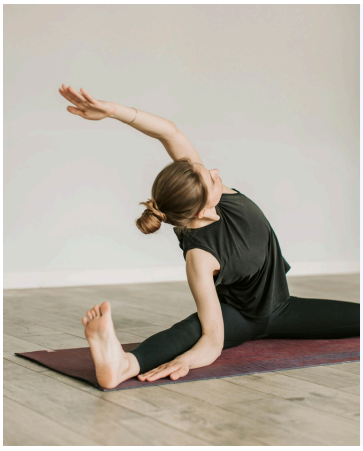
- Your goal: Adjust portions and focus (energy, recovery, or balance) based on what you’re working toward.
- Your schedule: Choose quick snacks or full meals depending on how close you train to eating.
- Your appetite: Go lighter if hunger is low and eat when it feels comfortable after workouts.

WHY WORKOUT NUTRITION TIMING MATTERS



Energy Availability

Your body relies on readily available fuel to perform well during exercise. Eating appropriately before a workout helps ensure your muscles and brain have access to energy, supporting strength, focus, and endurance. When nutrition timing is off, workouts can feel harder, less effective, and more fatiguing than they need to be.



Muscle Recovery & repair

Exercise creates small amounts of muscle stress that require proper nutrition to recover from. Post-workout meals or snacks provide the building blocks your body needs to repair muscle tissue and adapt to training. Consistent recovery nutrition can help reduce soreness, support muscle maintenance, and improve long-term training results.



Blood Sugar Balance & Performance

The timing of your meals influences how stable your blood sugar remains before, during, and after exercise. Balanced nutrition around workouts helps prevent sharp energy spikes and crashes that can affect performance and mood. Stable blood sugar supports more consistent workouts, better recovery, and steadier energy throughout the day.

CALORIES & MACRONUTRIENTS EXPLAINED

Calories and macronutrients are often talked about in workout nutrition, but they don't need to be tracked or measured to be useful concepts. Understanding what they represent can help you make more informed food choices before and after workouts, without turning nutrition into math.

What Are Calories?

Calories are simply a unit of energy. They represent how much energy food provides to your body.

Your body uses this energy to:

- Support movement and exercise
- Fuel daily activities
- Maintain basic bodily functions
- Support recovery after training

What Are Macronutrients?

Macronutrients are the main components of food that provide energy and support different functions in the body. There are three main macronutrients: carbohydrates, protein, and fats.

Each plays a unique role in training and recovery.

Calories & Macronutrients in Everyday Foods

Most meals naturally contain a mix of calories and macronutrients. A bowl of oats, a piece of fruit with yogurt, or a balanced lunch all provide energy and nourishment without needing to be broken down into numbers.

Recognizing that everyday foods already support your body helps remove pressure around "getting it right." The focus moving forward is choosing foods that work well for your workouts and recovery.



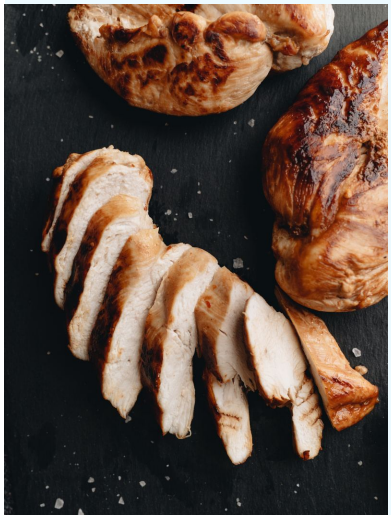


Carbohydrates = Energy for Movement

Carbohydrates are your body's preferred fuel for most workouts. They support performance during training and help restore energy afterward.

Including carbohydrate-rich foods around workouts can help:

- Support endurance and intensity
- Reduce fatigue during exercise
- Restore energy after training



Protein = Repair & Recovery

Protein provides the building blocks your body uses to repair and maintain muscle tissue after exercise.

Including protein around workouts helps:

- Support muscle repair
- Reduce excessive soreness
- Support adaptation to training over time



Fats = Balance & Support

Fats support hormone function, nutrient absorption, and overall nourishment. While they aren't the main fuel source during workouts, they play an important role in balanced meals before and after training.

Healthy fats help:

- Promote satiety
- Support overall health
- Create balanced, satisfying meals

These ideas are meant to support better food choices, not create pressure or rigid rules. Balanced meals can help support energy during training and recovery afterward without turning nutrition into a complex process. The next sections show how to apply these concepts in simple, practical ways around your workouts.

PRE-WORKOUT NUTRITION BASICS

What your body needs before exercise

Before a workout, your body needs accessible energy to support movement, focus, and endurance. Pre-workout nutrition helps prepare your muscles and nervous system while reducing early fatigue. The goal isn't a large meal, but enough fuel to train comfortably and effectively.

Carbohydrates, protein & fats — what matters most

Carbohydrates are the main fuel source for most workouts and support performance and intensity. Protein helps protect muscle tissue, especially during longer or more demanding sessions. Fats play a smaller role before exercise and are best kept moderate, as they digest more slowly.

Hydration basics

Hydration supports circulation, temperature control, and overall workout performance. Even mild dehydration can affect energy and focus, making training feel harder. Consistent fluid intake throughout the day works better than trying to hydrate all at once before exercise.





WHAT TO EAT BEFORE A WORKOUT

30–60 minutes before training
Choose light, easy-to-digest foods that provide quick energy without feeling heavy. Simple carbohydrates paired with a small amount of protein can help support energy and focus while minimizing digestive discomfort.

1–2 hours before training
A balanced meal works best when you have more time before exercise. Aim for carbohydrates for fuel, protein for muscle support, and a moderate amount of fat to help keep you satisfied without slowing digestion.

Early-morning / fasted workouts
Some people prefer to train with little or no food first thing in the morning. If energy feels low, a small snack or liquid option before training can help support performance without feeling too heavy.

Low-appetite options
When hunger is low, smaller portions or liquid foods can be easier to tolerate and digest. Smoothies, yogurt, fruit, or simple snacks can provide enough fuel to support your workout without feeling heavy or overwhelming.

PRE-WORKOUT FOOD IDEAS (BY TRAINING TYPE)



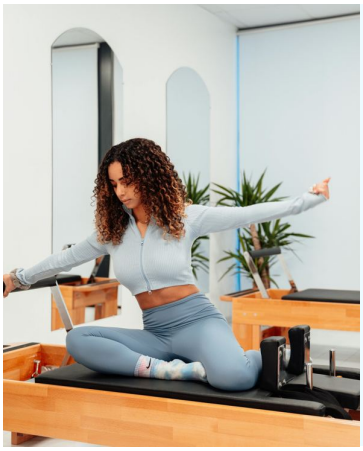
Strength & Resistance Training

Strength-focused workouts benefit from a combination of carbohydrates and protein to support power and muscle engagement. Carbohydrates help fuel lifts and sets, while protein supports muscle tissue during training. The goal is steady energy without feeling overly full or sluggish.



Cardio & Endurance Workouts

Cardio and endurance sessions rely more heavily on carbohydrates for sustained energy. Lighter, carb-focused options can help support stamina and prevent early fatigue, especially during longer or higher-intensity workouts. Protein can be kept moderate, depending on workout length and intensity.



Low-intensity Movement (yoga, walking, Pilates)

Gentle movement requires less fuel and often feels best with lighter or simpler foods. A small snack or easily digestible option can support comfort and focus without weighing you down. Some people may feel comfortable training with minimal or no food for these sessions.



POST-WORKOUT NUTRITION BASICS

Recovery window explained

The idea of a strict “post-workout window” is often overstated. While eating after training supports recovery, it doesn’t need to happen immediately or within a narrow timeframe. What matters most is consistently meeting your overall nutrition needs throughout the day.

Glycogen refill

Carbohydrates help restore glycogen, the stored energy used during workouts. Replenishing carbs after training supports energy levels, especially if you train frequently or have another workout planned. The amount needed depends on workout intensity, duration, and overall activity level.

Protein needs for muscle repair

Protein provides the building blocks needed to repair and maintain muscle after exercise. Including protein in a post-workout meal or snack supports recovery and training adaptations over time. Consistent protein intake throughout the day matters more than perfect timing.

Fluids & electrolytes

Fluids replace water lost through sweat and support circulation and temperature control. Electrolytes like sodium can be helpful after longer or sweat-heavy workouts. Staying hydrated throughout the day supports recovery better than relying on a single post-workout drink.

WHAT TO EAT AFTER A WORKOUT

Immediately after training

If you're hungry right after exercise, a light snack with protein and carbohydrates can support early recovery and muscle repair. This approach can be especially helpful after longer or more intense workouts, but it's not essential if a balanced meal is planned soon afterward.

Within 1–2 hours post-workout

A balanced meal within this timeframe supports muscle repair, energy replenishment, and overall recovery. Including protein, carbohydrates, and fluids helps restore what was used during training and prepares your body for your next workout or daily activities.

When you don't feel hungry

Appetite can be low after exercise, particularly following high-intensity or demanding sessions. In these situations, smaller portions or liquid options can make recovery nutrition easier and more comfortable. Focus on gentle nourishment and eat a full meal once hunger returns naturally.



POST-WORKOUT MEAL & SNACK IDEAS



Quick Recovery Snacks

Quick snacks are helpful when you need something simple and convenient after training. Combining protein with carbohydrates supports recovery without requiring a full meal. These options work well when time is limited or a meal is planned later.
Examples: Greek-style yogurt with fruit, protein smoothie, banana with nut butter, cottage cheese with berries.



Balanced recovery meals

Recovery meals provide more complete nourishment after exercise. Including protein, carbohydrates, healthy fats, and fluids supports muscle repair and energy replenishment. These meals are ideal after longer or more demanding workouts.
Examples: Grilled chicken with rice and vegetables, salmon with quinoa and salad, eggs with roasted potatoes and greens.



Plant-based & Dairy-free Options

Plant-based and dairy-free choices can support recovery when they include enough protein and carbohydrates. Combining legumes, grains, and plant proteins helps meet post-workout needs. Variety matters more than specific foods.
Examples: Tofu stir-fry with rice, lentil bowl with sweet potatoes, hummus with whole-grain pita and vegetables, plant-based protein smoothie.

FUEL QUALITY MATTERS

What you eat around your workouts plays an important role in how your body feels, performs, and recovers. Choosing nutrient-dense, minimally processed foods helps support steady energy during training and effective recovery afterward. Simple, whole-food choices can make workouts feel better and recovery more comfortable over time.

PROTEIN: CHOOSE LEAN, HIGH-QUALITY SOURCES

Protein supports muscle repair and helps your body recover from physical effort. After workouts, protein provides the building blocks needed to repair muscle tissue and adapt to training. Prioritizing high-quality, whole-food protein sources supports recovery without relying heavily on highly processed options.

Best Sources of Protein:

- Lean meats: chicken breast, turkey, lean beef cuts
- Fish & seafood: salmon, tuna, cod, shrimp
- Eggs and egg whites
- Low-fat dairy or Greek yogurt



HEALTHY FATS: FOCUS ON QUALITY

Healthy fats support hormone health, nutrient absorption, and overall nourishment. While fats aren't the main focus right before workouts, including them in meals before or after training helps create balanced, satisfying meals. Focus on whole-food, unsaturated fat sources rather than processed ones.

Best Sources of Healthy Fats:

- Avocado
- Nuts & seeds (almonds, walnuts, chia, flax)
- Olive oil & extra virgin olive oil
- Fatty fish (salmon, mackerel, sardines)



CARBOHYDRATES: GO FOR WHOLE, FIBER-RICH CHOICES

Carbohydrates provide fuel for workouts and help restore energy after exercise. Choosing whole, fiber-rich carbohydrate sources supports steady energy levels and recovery without sharp ups and downs. These foods help your body feel supported both during and after training.

Best Sources of Carbohydrates:



- Whole grains (oats, quinoa, brown rice, whole-wheat bread)
- Vegetables (especially leafy greens, broccoli, sweet potatoes
- Fruits (berries, apples, bananas, oranges)
- Legumes (beans, lentils, peas)

SUPPORTING DIGESTION AROUND WORKOUTS

Digestion plays an important role in workout comfort. Heavy, greasy, or highly processed foods can sometimes feel uncomfortable when eaten too close to exercise. Choosing simpler, minimally processed foods before training can help reduce bloating, cramping, or sluggishness during movement.

After workouts, digestion may still be settling, especially after intense sessions. Gentle, familiar foods can help support recovery without overwhelming your system. Paying attention to how different foods make you feel can help you refine your personal pre- and post-workout routine over time.

Digestion Tip

Eating simpler foods closer to workouts and saving heavier meals for later can improve comfort and performance.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

Training Under-Fueled
Going into workouts without enough fuel can lead to low energy, dizziness, poor performance, and slower progress over time. When the body doesn't have adequate carbohydrates or overall energy, it may rely more heavily on stress hormones, making workouts feel harder and recovery less effective overall. Even small, balanced pre-workout snacks can support better focus, endurance, and strength during training.

Skipping Recovery Nutrition
After exercise, the body needs nutrients to repair muscles, replenish energy, and support recovery. Skipping post-workout nutrition may increase soreness, delay recovery, and affect future workouts. A combination of protein and carbohydrates helps the body adapt to exercise and supports long-term consistency.

Over-Reliance on Supplements
Supplements are often marketed as essential for fitness performance and recovery, but they are not a replacement for real, nourishing food. Over-reliance on powders or pills can lead to nutrient gaps, unnecessary expense, and missed benefits of whole foods. Whole foods provide vitamins, minerals, fiber, and phytonutrients that supplements can't fully replace. Supplements should support a balanced, not replace it.

Ignoring Hydration Needs
Focusing only on food while neglecting hydration can significantly impact workout performance and recovery. Even mild dehydration may reduce strength, endurance, and concentration. Fluids help regulate body temperature, support circulation, and aid nutrient transport to muscles.

Remember, fueling your body doesn't need to be complicated. Small, consistent choices before and after workouts can make a meaningful difference in energy, performance, and recovery. Focus on progress over perfection and build habits that feel sustainable for your lifestyle.

SPECIAL CONSIDERATIONS

Everyone's body responds differently to food and exercise. These considerations can help you adjust pre- and post-workout nutrition in a way that feels supportive, comfortable, and sustainable based on your individual needs.



Weight Loss Goals

When weight loss is a goal, pre- and post-workout nutrition should still support energy and recovery. Skipping fuel entirely can lead to low energy, poor workout performance, or increased hunger later in the day. Balanced meals and snacks that include protein and fiber-rich foods can help support training while promoting steady appetite and consistency.



Muscle Building Goals

Supporting muscle growth requires consistent nourishment around training. Pre-workout foods can help support workout intensity, while post-workout meals support muscle repair and adaptation. Prioritizing regular meals with adequate protein and carbohydrates helps your body respond positively to strength training over time.



Blood Sugar Balance & Energy Crashes

Large gaps between meals or highly refined foods can sometimes lead to energy highs and lows around workouts. Choosing balanced meals and snacks with a mix of carbohydrates, protein, and fats can help support steadier energy levels. Paying attention to timing and food quality may reduce post-workout fatigue or energy crashes.



Digestive Sensitivity

Some people experience digestive discomfort around exercise, especially with heavy or unfamiliar foods. Opting for simpler, easy-to-digest options before workouts and gentler recovery foods afterward can help improve comfort. Listening to your body and adjusting food choices based on tolerance is key.

SAMPLE PRE & POST WORKOUT PAIRINGS

Seeing how foods can be paired before and after workouts can make planning feel simpler and more approachable. These examples are meant to guide you, not prescribe exact meals—feel free to adjust portions and food choices based on your preferences and appetite.

Training Day Examples

On a typical training day, pairing light fuel before exercise with balanced nourishment afterward can support both performance and recovery. Pre-workout foods help provide energy for movement, while post-workout meals support muscle repair and energy restoration later in the day.

Example:

- Pre-workout: fruit with yogurt or toast with nut butter
- Post-workout: protein source with grains and vegetables

LIGHT VS INTENSE WORKOUT DAYS

Not all workouts require the same level of fueling. Lighter movement days often feel best with simpler, smaller meals, while more intense training days may benefit from more structured meals before and after exercise.

Light workout day example:

- Pre-workout: small snack or no food if comfortable
- Post-workout: balanced meal or nourishing snack

Intense workout day example:

- Pre-workout: carbohydrate-focused snack with some protein
- Post-workout: balanced meal with protein, carbohydrates, and fluids

QUICK DECISION GUIDE

When planning what to eat before a workout, the amount of time you have matters more than finding the "perfect" food. Use this simple guide to make supportive choices without overthinking.

If You Have ~30 Minutes Before Training

Choose a light, easy-to-digest snack that provides quick energy without feeling heavy. Smaller portions work best when time is limited.

Examples: fruit with yogurt, toast with nut butter, a smoothie, or a small snack you tolerate well.



If You Have 1–2 Hours Before Training

A balanced meal works well when you have more time before exercise. Including carbohydrates, protein, and some fat helps support energy, comfort, and workout performance.

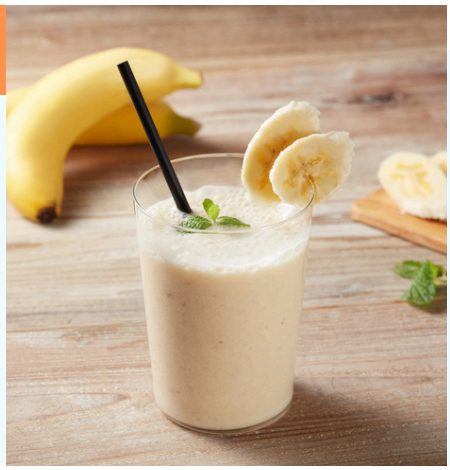
Examples: a grain bowl with protein and vegetables, eggs with toast and fruit.



If You Have No Appetite

It's okay if you don't feel hungry before a workout. In these cases, a smaller portion or liquid option can be easier to manage and still provide some support.

Examples: a smoothie, yogurt, fruit, or simply fluids if food doesn't feel right.



SUPPLEMENTS
WHAT'S OPTIONAL VS NOT NEEDED

Nutrition around workouts works best when it starts with real food. Meals and snacks provide the energy and nourishment needed for training and recovery, while supplements remain optional rather than essential.

For most people, consistent meals, balanced food choices, and hydration do more to support energy and recovery than any supplement.

PRE-WORKOUT SUPPLEMENTS (OPTIONAL)	POST-WORKOUT SUPPLEMENTS (OPTIONAL)
Caffeine (coffee or tea) Some people use caffeine to feel more alert before training. It's optional and not necessary if you already feel energized from food and rest.	**Protein powder or shakes** Protein shakes can be convenient when a meal isn't available. They are not more effective than whole foods and work best as a convenience option.
Pre-workout powders These products are designed to boost energy or focus but aren't required. Many people find that a light snack and hydration provide similar support.	**Recovery drinks** These are often marketed for faster recovery, but balanced meals and fluids usually provide what the body needs after training.

Supplements You Don't Need

- Fat burners or metabolism boosters: These products aren't necessary and don't replace consistent food habits.
- Specialty blends or advanced formulas: Most people can support training and recovery without complex or expensive products.

COMMON QUESTIONS & REASSURING ANSWERS

Questions around eating before and after workouts are very common. Nutrition advice can feel confusing or contradictory, especially when routines, schedules, and appetite change from day to day. These answers are meant to offer clarity and reassurance—there is flexibility, and small adjustments often work better than strict rules.

Do I Need to Eat Before Every Workout?

No, eating before every workout isn't required. Some people feel better with food before training, while others feel comfortable exercising with little or no food, especially for lighter or shorter sessions.

The goal is to support your energy and comfort. If you notice low energy, dizziness, or poor focus during workouts, adding a small snack beforehand may help. If you feel fine without eating, that can also be okay.

Is It Okay to Work Out Without Eating First?

Yes, for some people and some types of workouts, training without eating first can feel completely comfortable. This is more common with low-intensity movement or shorter sessions.

If workouts feel harder than expected or recovery feels slower, it may be helpful to experiment with a light snack or liquid option beforehand. Pay attention to how your body responds rather than following a fixed rule.

Do Short Workouts Need Special Fueling?

Short workouts usually don't require anything special. If you're moving for a brief period and feel energized, your regular meals may already be enough.

However, if short workouts still feel draining or are part of a busy day with long gaps between meals, a small snack before or after can help support energy and recovery. Simplicity works well here.

What If I Train Late in the Evening?

Evening workouts don't require a different approach, but timing can feel trickier. A balanced meal earlier in the evening often supports training better than exercising on an empty stomach.

After late workouts, choose something nourishing but comfortable rather than heavy or overly large. Light meals or snacks can still support recovery without interfering with rest or sleep.

What If I Miss My Post-Workout Meal?

Missing a post-workout meal once in a while is not a problem. Recovery doesn't depend on a single meal or perfect timing.

What matters more is overall nourishment across the day. Eating a balanced meal later on still supports recovery, even if it's not immediately after training.

What If My Appetite Changes After Exercise?

Appetite can vary after workouts—sometimes hunger increases, other times it decreases. Both responses are normal.

If appetite is low, smaller portions or liquid options can be easier. If hunger is higher, a more substantial meal may feel supportive. Let appetite guide portion size rather than forcing food at a specific time.

There is no single "right" way to eat around workouts. Energy levels, digestion, schedule, and preferences all matter. Flexible choices, consistency over time, and listening to your body create better results than strict rules.



THANK YOU

Thank you for trusting Enchanted Medical Aesthetics with your wellness journey. Use this guide as a flexible reference, adapt it to your routine, and bring your questions to your next visit. Our team is here to support you every step of the way.

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Doctor of Nursing Practice

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